receiving end of the steadily normalised violence were the Kashmiri Pandits, who were amongst the oldest inhabitants of the valley. Fifty Hindu homes were burned down in the Anantnag district of south Kashmir in February 1986, setting the stage for the mass exodus of Kashmiri Pandits, that began in February 1990. The Pandits had constituted 1,25,000 out of the 30,00,000 Kashmiris in the valley. Fearing further attacks, with threats being announced through Srinagar's Urdu daily *Al-Safa* and loudspeakers at mosques, and with official announcements that refugee camps were being set up in the valley, most Pandits chose to move to Jammu and other parts of India.[6] Slowly, the Pandit population was reduced from over 75,000 families in January 1990 to around 650 families in 2014. It was a blow to the philosophy of 'Kashmiriyat', from which the state has never quite recovered.

Even though much of the insurgency had thus unfolded according to Gen. Zia's plans, the Pakistan Army's hopes of liberating Kashmir were foiled. Zia had expected Indian troops to stay in Sri Lanka battling Tamil insurgents much longer, but they returned in March 1990 as India pulled out of Sri Lanka, just as the Pak-sponsored insurgency took off in the valley. Earlier, warnings by Indian Army commanders in Jammu and Kashmir were ignored by Rajiv Gandhi, who had just been bruised by a shoddily implemented intervention in Sri Lanka. But, once the contours of Pakistan's plan became more apparent, a panic-stricken New Delhi Government decided, for the first time, to launch the Indian Army in a counter-insurgency role (later for counter-terrorism operations) within the Kashmir Valley, in 1990. Soon, the AFSPA was implemented across the state of Jammu and Kashmir. It gave Indian troops legal cover to operate freely in the state, but the AFSPA soon came under a lot of criticism for the alleged human rights abuses by Indian troops. The central government remained in denial about the insurgency for quite some time, even though the police had arrested the first group of Pakistan-trained men in as early as September 1988. Their numbers kept increasing as they infiltrated across the LoC, guided by the local shepherds through craggy pathways. By mid-1989, Srinagar descended into violence and a 'Quit Kashmir' movement was